

PasteCal — UX Review

First-run & onboarding, through the lens of "instant start" (Instacalc) — plus a recommendation on quick-start pills.
Prepared for Kalid · June 18, 2026 · Reviewed: live homepage (desktop + mobile), help panel, quick-add, claim flow.

Bottom line. PasteCal already nails the hardest part of the "no-ceremony" promise: you land in a working, editable calendar with a real URL and a sample event — **no login, no setup, no blank page**. That is the spirit of a microwave's "quick 30." The gap isn't the engine, it's the **visibility of the one-tap action** and the **blank-scenario problem** for first-timers. Two cheap moves close it: (1) make natural-language Quick Add the always-visible primary action, and (2) add a small row of scenario "Start with" pills. Recommendation on pills: **Yes — ship a tightly-scoped version**.

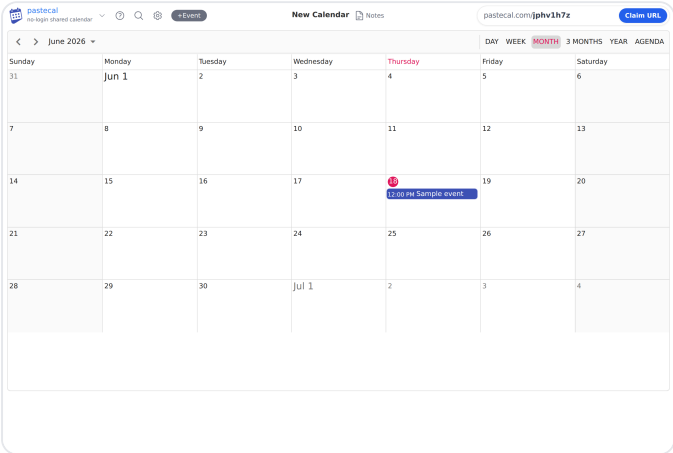
1. What's the "quick 30" equivalent?

A microwave's "quick 30" works for two reasons: it does the **single most common thing** (add 30s) and it needs **zero configuration** — one press and it's already running. Crucially, a microwave actually ships **two** kinds of no-ceremony buttons, and PasteCal maps cleanly onto both:

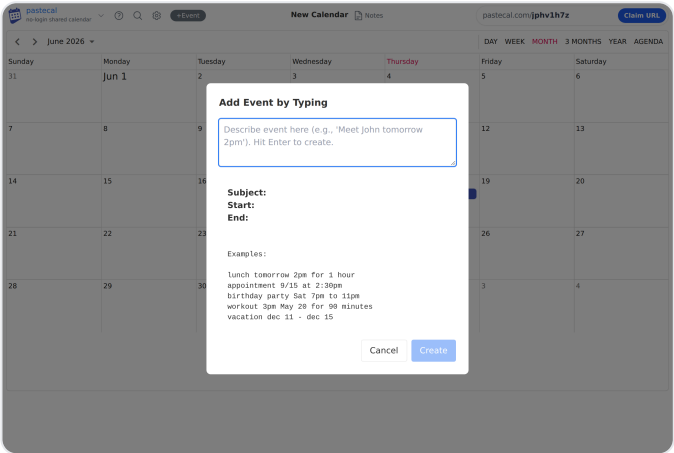
Microwave	PasteCal equivalent today	State
" +30s" / Quick Start one button, most-common action, already cooking	Auto-created calendar + sample event. You arrive at <code>pastecal.com/9hemdulq</code> already editable, with a 12:00 PM "Sample event" placeholder.	STRONG — keep
The "+30s" you press again and again	Natural-language Quick Add — type <i>"lunch tomorrow 2pm"</i> → Enter. This is the truest one-action primitive, but it's hidden behind <code>Cmd+E</code> / a small "+Event" / a mobile kebab.	UNDER-SURFACED
Preset buttons (Popcorn, Beverage, Pizza)	Does not exist yet. No scenario starters on the homepage — this is exactly what "quick pills" would be.	OPPORTUNITY

So, the literal answer: PasteCal's "quick 30" is the **auto-calendar + Quick Add typing box**. It already exists — it's just not loud enough. Before adding anything new, make that single primitive the visible, default, one-tap action (see §4). *Then* pills become the "preset buttons" layer on top.

2. First-run experience (what a new user actually sees)



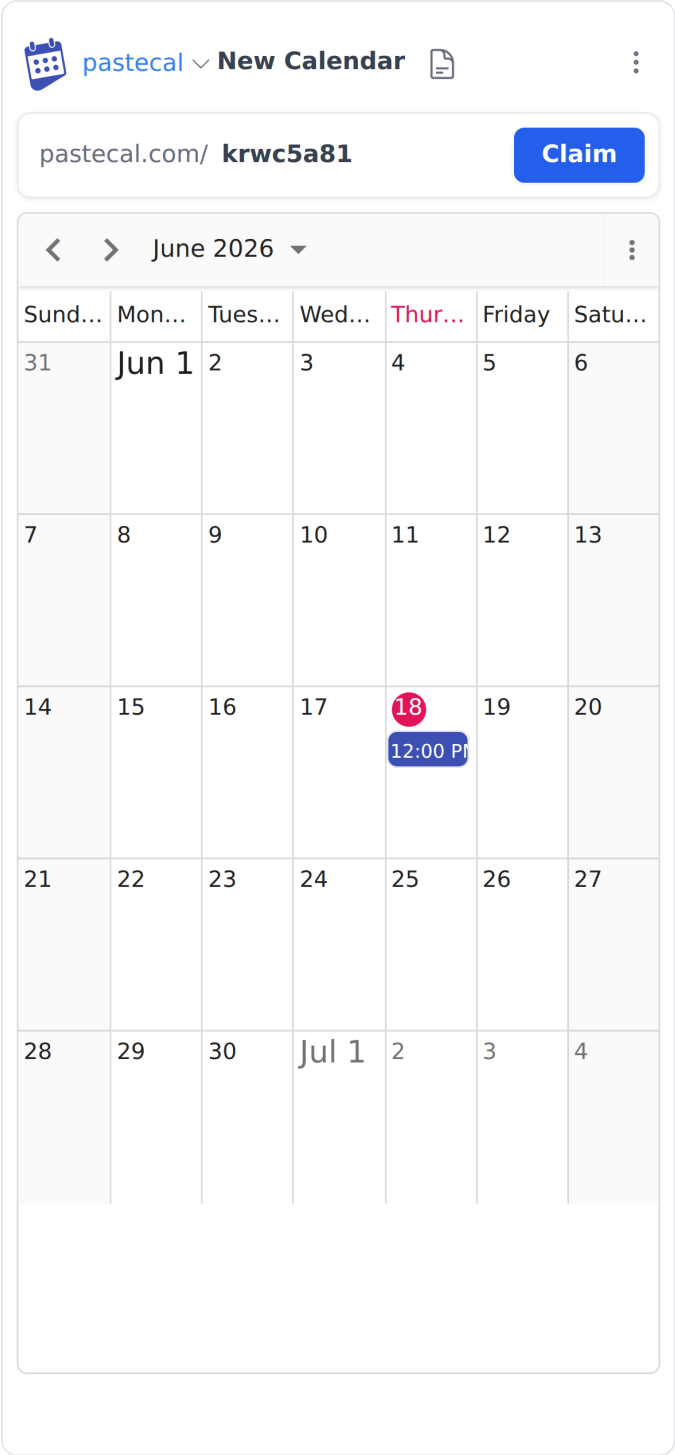
Desktop landing. No login wall. Working month view, random claimable URL top-right, "Claim URL" CTA, and a pre-seeded "Sample event." This is a great instant-start — the user is already inside the product.



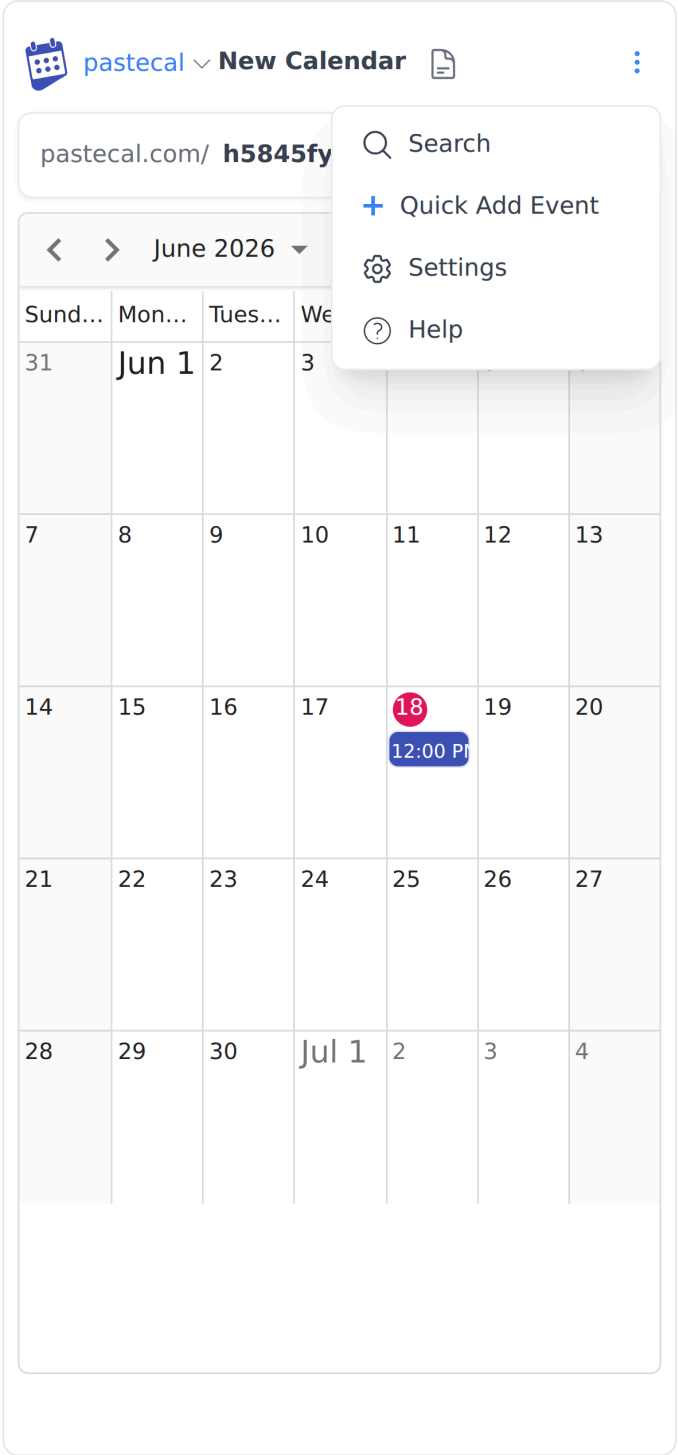
The hidden gem. "Add Event by Typing" — natural language ("birthday party Sat 7pm to 11pm"). This is the Instacalc-style instant input. Today it requires knowing `Cmd+E` or finding "+Event."

Strengths: zero-friction entry, immediate working surface, a forgiving sample event, and an honest URL-claim model. **Friction:** the most powerful "just type it" path is the least discoverable, and the sample event is a small chore to clear. A first-timer with a blank calendar still faces a quiet "now what?" moment.

3. Where the no-ceremony promise leaks



Mobile landing. Clean, and the claim pill is prominent. But there is **no visible add-event affordance** in the header — the primary action is gone.



Mobile "⋮" menu. "Quick Add Event" is buried one tap deep, alongside Search/Settings/Help. On the device where typing-to-add matters most, it's the hardest to reach.

- **FIX Quick Add is hidden on mobile** (in the kebab). The flagship instant-input is demoted on touch — the exact opposite of "no ceremony."
- **FIX Discoverability of typing-to-add.** Desktop relies on `Cmd+E` or a low-contrast "+Event" chip; few will find it.
- **FIX Blank-scenario moment.** After the sample event, a new user has no nudge toward *what* to build (trip? team? RSVP?).

- **NOTE** Dead "Name your calendar" modal. The claim-intervention dialog (specced in `creation_flow.md`) is unreachable — there are two `create()` methods in `app.js` and the second silently overrides the first, so clicking Claim navigates immediately and the naming nudge never fires.

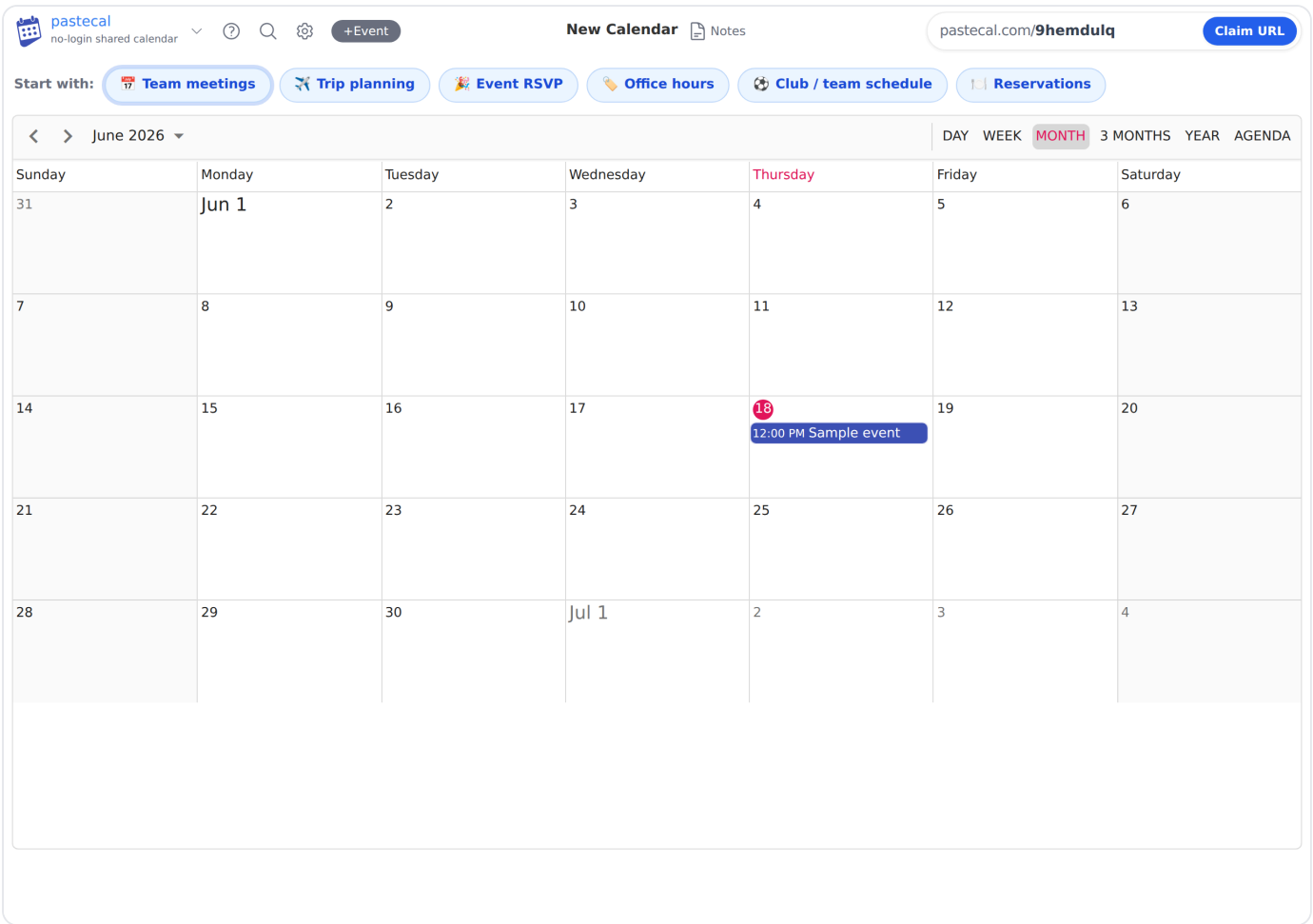
4. Recommendation A — make the "quick 30" loud (do this first)

Cheapest, highest-leverage. No new concepts; just promote what exists.

1. **Always-visible Quick Add.** Put a persistent "+ Add event" as the primary button on desktop *and* a sticky FAB (or first-class header button) on mobile — not in the kebab. One tap opens the type-to-add box.
2. **Show the magic in the field.** Rotating placeholder in the URL/empty state: *"Try: dinner Friday 7pm"* so the natural-language power is self-evident.
3. **Replace the sample event with a ghost prompt.** Instead of a real event to delete, render a faint *"Tap any time, or type 'lunch tomorrow 2pm'"* watermark (per `ui-ideas.md`). Cleaner start, still educational.

5. Recommendation B — quick "Start with" pills

Should we have quick pills for common scenarios on the homepage? **Yes** — as the "preset buttons" layer, scoped tightly. They solve the blank-scenario moment and teach use-cases the hero copy already lists (team schedules, clubs, trips, RSVPs).



Mockup (rendered in the live app): a single "Start with:" row between the top bar and the grid. Tapping a pill seeds a tailored starter calendar and suggests a slug (e.g. Trip planning → `/trip-2026` with day/agenda view + a couple of example items).

What each pill should do (not just filter — start)

- **Seed a relevant template:** 2–3 example events, the best view (Agenda for trips, Week for office hours), sensible title.
- **Suggest a memorable slug** — quietly fixing the "random ID never claimed" problem from `creation_flow.md` .
- **Stay one tap from undo** — picking a pill shouldn't feel like a commitment.

Guardrails (so pills don't add their own ceremony)

- KEEP** Only on a fresh/unclaimed calendar. Hide pills once the user starts editing or claims a URL — they're a starting nudge, not chrome.
- KEEP** One row, dismissible, no layout thrash. Don't push the grid down on mobile; collapse to a single "Start with a template ▼" entry on small screens.
- KEEP** Quietly themeable later. Pills are a natural home for seasonal/marketing presets without touching core UI.
- MEASURE** Instrument it. Pill-click → claim conversion is the success metric. If a pill doesn't lift claims, cut it.

Alternatives considered

Option	Trade-off
Pills that seed templates (recommended)	Best blank-page fix + teaches use-cases + nudges claiming. Slightly more build (needs small templates).
Pills that just pre-fill Quick Add text	Cheaper, but lower payoff — still leaves an empty calendar.
A full template gallery / modal	More ceremony — exactly what we're trying to avoid. Over-built for a "paste & go" product.
Do nothing, only promote Quick Add	Valid & cheapest; solves discoverability but not the "what should I make?" moment.

6. Suggested order of work

#	Change	Effort	Payoff
1	Surface Quick Add as a persistent primary button (desktop + mobile, out of the kebab)	Low	High
2	Ghost-prompt empty state instead of a deletable sample event	Low	Medium
3	"Start with" pills that seed a template + suggest a slug (fresh calendars only)	Medium	High
4	Rotating natural-language placeholder to advertise type-to-add	Low	Medium
5	Fix the duplicate <code>create()</code> so the "Name your calendar" nudge actually fires	Low	Medium

One-sentence answer to your question: Yes, add quick pills — but treat them as the microwave's *preset buttons*, layered on top of a louder, always-visible "+30s" *Quick Add*, which is the change that most directly delivers the "just gets things going without the ceremony" feel.